My first match as captain was against Australia at the Kotla in New Delhi in October 1996, and we were keen to bounce back after the series defeat in England in the summer. We also needed to win the Test to keep our amazing home Test record intact. We managed to do so, with Nayan Mongia, our wicketkeeper and stand-in opener, scoring a remarkable 152. It wasn't a bad start as skipper.

Unusually, Australia had travelled all the way to India just to play a single Test, which was intended to mark the inauguration of the Border–Gavaskar Trophy, named after two of world cricket's greatest icons. At least there was a good reason for that one-off game; at other times it was a little difficult to understand the thinking behind some of our shorter tours. A couple of years earlier, for example, we went all the way to New Zealand for one Test match and four ODIs, with no practice games, and that was considered a tour of New Zealand! We also played our fair share of two-Test series over the years and they are not altogether satisfactory either – you blink four times and a two-Test series is over!

Next on the horizon was a home Test series against South Africa, which was preceded by another one-day tournament, the Titan Cup, involving India, Australia and South Africa. It was no small achievement to beat Australia and South Africa, two of the best teams in the world at the time, on our way to the title. In the final at the Wankhede on 6 November, I scored 67 in our modest 220, with Jadeja adding 43, and then it was all down to Anil Kumble, who took four wickets as we bowled the South Africans out for 185, winning the match by 35 runs. It was a very welcome victory after our disappointing loss to Sri Lanka in the World Cup semi-final and it was particularly satisfying for me, because I had experimented with something radically different as captain.

After Srinath and Venkatesh Prasad had bowled good first spells and Anil had picked up a couple of wickets, I had to turn to Robin Singh, our all-rounder, for the fifth bowler's quota. Robin bowled medium pace and was extremely accurate. I decided to go with a four–five field. In an ODI, it is very unusual, with a medium-pacer operating, for there to be only four fielders on the off side and five on the on. I had no deep point and had fielders at third man, short point, cover and long off. On the on side I had fielders at fine leg, short square leg, short midwicket, deep square leg and long on. I asked Robin to bowl stump-to-stump and make sure not a single ball was pitched outside the off stump, otherwise the